

CHAPTER 12

Grassroots Democracy – Part 3: Local Government in Urban Areas

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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The Big Questions

1 What are urban local bodies and what are their functions?

✔ ANSWER

Urban local bodies are the local government structures in cities and towns (Municipal Corporation, Municipal Council, Nagar Panchayat, ward committees).

Functions:

- take care of infrastructure (roads, water, drains)
- garbage collection and disposal; maintaining burial grounds
- checking that government schemes are implemented
- collecting local taxes and fines
- some role in planning the area's economic and social development

2 Why are they important in governance and democracy?

✔ ANSWER

- They are decentralised: local people get a direct say in how their area is managed.
- Their members are elected, so they represent the local citizens.

- They solve local problems quickly (a water leak, a blocked drain) because they are close to the people.
- Citizens can take part in decisions, which is what a participatory democracy means.

⭐ Introduction · Let's Explore

1 **Why is a city like Kolkata, Chennai or Mumbai more complex and diverse than a village or a town?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- A big city has a very large population living close together.
- People come from many States, speak many languages and follow different religions and cultures.
- They do many kinds of jobs (factories, offices, shops, transport, services).
- The city needs many services: water, roads, transport, garbage disposal, hospitals.

So a city is more complex and diverse, and its government also has to be more complex.

2 **With your classmates, make a list of diverse communities residing in any city that you are familiar with. How many were you able to list? What else do you observe in the list?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Sample (Delhi): Punjabis, Biharis, Bengalis, Tamils, Malayalis, Marathis, Gujaratis, people from the North-East; Hindus, Muslims, Sikhs, Christians, Jains, Buddhists.

We could list about 15 communities.

Observation: people from almost every part of India live together in the city. They speak different languages and celebrate different festivals, yet share the same city services.

⭐ Let's Explore · Fig. 12.2

1 **In Fig. 12.2, what similarities and differences do you notice between the Panchayati Raj system and the urban local government?**

✔ ANSWER

Similarities:

- Both are local government, at the base of the pyramid below State and Union Governments.
- Both have elected members who represent local people.
- Both have several levels, starting with the people at the bottom (Gram Sabha / People of the Ward).

Differences:

Panchayati Raj (rural)	Urban local bodies
For villages	For cities and towns

Three tiers: Gram Panchayat, Panchayat Samiti, Zila Panchayat	Municipal Corporation / Municipal Council / Nagar Panchayat
Gram Sabha of the village people	Ward Committees and people of the ward

⭐ Urban Local Bodies · Let's Explore

1 **Can you think of four or five more actions that responsible citizens might take to help their area of the city?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Not throw litter on roads; use dustbins.
- Save water and electricity; switch off street taps and lights left on.
- Report a blocked drain, broken streetlight or damaged road to the ward office.
- Avoid single-use plastic and plant and care for trees.
- Pay property tax and water charges on time.
- Take part in cleanliness drives and health camps.

🤔 Think About It

1 **Indore in Madhya Pradesh has been awarded the cleanest city in India under the Swachh Survekshan government scheme for seven**

years in a row. What could have been the role of Indore citizens in this achievement?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- They segregated waste (wet and dry) at home and gave it to the garbage vans.
- They did not throw litter or spit on roads and used dustbins.
- They followed the instructions of the Municipal Corporation and paid their charges.
- They took part in cleanliness campaigns and encouraged others to keep the city clean.

Without the citizens' help, the Corporation alone could not have kept the city so clean.

⭐ Let's Explore · Types of urban local bodies

1 **Select a few cities from your State and neighbouring States. How will you find out if they have a Nagar Panchayat, Municipal Council or Municipal Corporation? Draw a table with the names of the cities and the type of urban local body each has.**

(Rule in the book: population above 10 lakh → Municipal Corporation; 1–10 lakh → Municipal Council; smaller → Nagar Panchayat.)

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

How to find out: look at the city's official website, ask the local ward office or elders, check a newspaper or the State's urban development website, or use the population rule.

Sample table (Madhya Pradesh and neighbours):

City	Type of urban local body
Indore (MP)	Municipal Corporation
Bhopal (MP)	Municipal Corporation
Jaipur (Rajasthan)	Municipal Corporation
Lucknow (Uttar Pradesh)	Municipal Corporation
A small town near you	Municipal Council or Nagar Panchayat (check locally)

2 **How do urban local bodies fund their activities? (Hint: look at the functions of Indore Municipal Corporation in Fig. 12.4.) Are some of them paid services?**

✔ ANSWER

They collect money from:

- property tax and water charges
- fees for trade licences, business and hoardings
- fines
- charges for services such as marriage certificates, fire services, tree cutting, debris clearance

Yes, some are paid services on request: water tanker, septic tanker, auditorium, funeral van, mobile toilet, ambulance.

(They also get funds from the State Government.)

❓ Questions, activities and projects

1 **On your way to school, you and your friends notice that a water pipe is leaking. A lot of water is being wasted. What would you and your friends do?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Report it at once to the municipal office, ward office or the helpline / app of the urban local body.
- Tell our teacher, parents or a ward committee member so that they can also complain.
- If there is a valve nearby that is safe to close, ask an adult to close it.
- Check later whether it was repaired; if not, report again.

Reporting promptly prevents waste of precious water.

2 **Invite a member of an urban local body near you to your class. Discuss their role and responsibilities. Prepare a set of questions to ask them.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Sample questions:

- Which ward do you represent and how were you elected?
- What are your main duties?
- What are the biggest problems of our area?
- How does the body get money for its work?
- How can citizens report problems like water leaks or garbage?
- How can students help to keep our area clean and safe?

3 **Discuss with adult members of your family and neighbourhood, and make a list of their expectations from the urban local bodies.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Clean drinking water every day
- Regular garbage collection
- Good roads and working streetlights
- Clean drains, no waterlogging in the rains
- Parks and playgrounds
- Quick action on complaints
- Honest use of tax money

4 **Make a list of characteristics of a good urban local body.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Its members are elected fairly and listen to the people.
- It provides basic services (water, cleanliness, roads, lights) on time.
- It acts quickly on complaints.
- It uses tax money honestly and openly.
- It involves citizens, for example through ward committees.
- It plans for the area's future development.

5 **What are the similarities and differences between the Panchayati Raj system in rural areas and the urban local bodies?**

✔ ANSWER

Similarities:

- Both are local government, decentralised and close to the people.
- Both have elected members who represent the local citizens.
- Both look after local needs like water, cleanliness and roads, and check government schemes.
- Both need citizens to do their duties.

Differences:

Panchayati Raj	Urban local bodies

Works in villages	Works in cities and towns
Gram Panchayat, Panchayat Samiti, Zila Panchayat	Municipal Corporation, Municipal Council, Nagar Panchayat
Gram Sabha of all village adults	Wards and ward committees
Smaller, people know each other, more can take part directly	Bigger and more complex, people take part through representatives

🎉 **Chapter 12 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**